Our Letter Box.

Rampant Sabbatarianism.

Sir,—It appears that some municipal councils in town and country are putting their heads together with a view to curtailing the outdoor amusements open to young Australia on Sunday. They mean to get the Government to proscribe cricket, tennis, and football, as being derogatory to the sanctity of the Lord's day. I fail to see what harm comes of engaging in such amusements on Sunday, provided they are confined to the afternoon, when there is no danger of interfering with the claims of religion, or disturbing people at church. Rather, I should think the harm lies in the opposite direction, and that religion and morality will be more injured than served by closing up these avenues of wholesome recreation to young people. Extremes provoke reaction, and persons will be strongly inclined to indemnify themselves by license in their mature years for the unreasonable restraints they suffered from in their boyhood. The epoch in English history that stands out more than any other for its shameless immorality is the Restoration, and we know that it came as a rebound from the absurd Puritan austerity of the Commonwealth. Again, how often do we not meet Scotchmen who, when asked why they no longer go to church, reply that they have too vivid a memory of the iron discipline of Sabbatarian restriction that darkened the joys of their youth. But if this occurs in the green wood, what may we expect in the dry? If in its congenial home of Scotch mist, pluvious climate, and gloomy mountains, Sabbatarianism is an infliction hardly tolerable to the youthful victim, what must it be in a land like ours, where we have a riot of sunshine from January to December, and where under its exhilarating influence, the animal spirits of average boyhood attain an exuberance that imperiously demands an outlet at peril of explosion.

Do these well-meaning aldermen ever trouble to enquire how our people will be likely to be employed, should they be denied a healthful vent for their superfluous vitality, during the long, sunshiny hours of the Sunday afternoon? Only the very few are of so religious a temperament as to care to put in the time in prayer and pious reading. What will the others be at? Frequenting gambling-schools, aimlessly lolling and lounging about, tempting the devil to tempt them, playing the mischievous pranks that come so ready to idle hands or idle minds; or, it may be, taking a leisurely stroll with an extemporised sweetheart, to fill the lazy hours with soft nonsense, and, perhaps, something worse. Which kind of occupation has the better effect on character, cricket, for instance, or that resorted to under stress of puritanic restriction? Which is the more conducive to the interests of religion and morality? I don't think any one much acquainted with boyish human nature will take long to decide.

I maintain, then, that to cut off boys from these wholesome amusements is to run counter to common sense and religion. I also maintain that it is to take up a position at variance with history and the spirit of the institution it is meant to honour. Some people, even among those possessed of intelligence and education, never appear to grasp the distinction between the Jewish Sabbath and the Christian Sunday. The fact escapes them that these are two different institutions, with different motives underlying their observance. One is in honour of the mysterious rest of the Creator, when His creature work was finished; the other is in honour of the great mystery of our Lord's resurrection, and the difference in character between the events they commemorate is naturally the ground of the difference between the two institutions. Both, as being days of rest, may be called the Sabbath, but not with equal propriety, as of the elder institution rest for man and beast is the primary feature, whereas of the younger the primary feature is worship, praise and thanksgiving for the mercy, love and triumph with which our Saviour enriched the world, and that are so strongly suggested by the mystery that is the corner-stone of Christian belief. It appears at once that as nothing can be more out of harmony with the character of the Christian Sunday than gloom or sourness, so nothing is more in keeping with it than joy and cheerfulness.

But there is something still wanting to a full statement of the untenable position taken up by those sticklers for "Sabbath" observance. What right, anyhow, have these gentlemen as Protestants to lay down the law as to what is to be done or not done on Sunday? Sunday is a Catholic institution, and its claims to observance can be defended only on Catholic principles. If the "Bible and the Bible only is the religion of Protestants," if "whatever is not read therein nor may be proved thereby" has no claim on their faith or observance, what scrap of title can they show for all their dogmatic insistence as to the requirements of the Lord's Day? From beginning to end of Scripture there is not a single passage that warrants the transfer of weekly public worship from the last day of the week to the first. Thus Sunday observance is an incongruous adjunct of the Protestant faith, utterly out of keeping with its fundamental principle, and strongly suggests a religion that suffered sadly from too much hurry in the making.

If any Sabbatarian wants to know the proper method of spending the Sunday the Catholic Church is the natural source to apply to for information. Under her direction the Sunday supplanted the Jewish Sabbath, and she is, therefore, the best fitted to settle any dispute as to its claims. She has no sympathy with a Puritan or Scotch Sabbath, and still less with the "Continental Sunday" of German Lutherans and French infidels. She forbids all servile work, and requires the day to be devoted to public prayer and worship and hearing the word of God, but these duties fulfilled she has no objection to such hours as remain being employed in any form of innocent outdoor amusement. This is the true view of Sunday observance, and it is the view that is bound to prevail, for besides the prestige of Catholic opinion, it has on its side the combined force of patent commonsense and Australian sunshine. Indeed, for many years there has been a "stream of tendency" setting in this wholesome direction. Half a century ago there were Protestant sects that couldn't think of admitting flowers or instrumental music into their churches. Well, they have made friends with the flowers and become reconciled to the music, and I have no doubt that before long such relics of Sabbatarianism as remain will have departed, without a mourner to follow the hearse to the forlorn realm of defunct superstitions.—Yours truly,

M. LONG.

St. Vincent's Hospital.

Sir,—It is very gratifying to every true, sensible-minded person in this community who had the pleasure of reading the Hon. John See's statement why the £1000 was granted to that grand and noble institution which has done so much good to those who have been there. It is a great pity that Alderman Thomas Jessep, J.P., M.L.A., L.O.L., &c., could not find something else to talk about than insult St. Vincent's, the devoted kind Sisters, and the able medical staff. It is to be hoped he has commenced to learn a little sense.—Yours &c.,

J. W. R. CLARKE,
Church of England,
and member of Christ Church.

"Herald House,"
31 Bucknell-street, Newtown,
August 18, 1900.

Concerning "Yer Honor" and the Stage Irishman.

Sir,—Our Tory friends, the anti-Home Rulers, of aristocratic instincts, who have a snug and unalterable idea that Irishmen are born to be slaves—with no higher ambition in life than to take "the Queen's shilling," or become menials to some swashbuckler or other in the army, often pay us a compliment like the following, which I clipped from a Catholic paper of the 3rd inst., published in one of the other colonies, and which is doubtless considered genuinely humourous and correct by that paper:—

"A Scotch-Irishman.—A distinguished Indian Office—Scotch to the core—never lost an opportunity of advertising his countrymen. One evening at mess he had a large number of guests, and had a fine specimen of a Highland piper on duty beside his chair. To draw attention to the man's splendid appearance, he turned to him and said: 'What pairt o' Scotland do you come from, my mon?' With a punctilious salute, the reply was: 'Tipperary, yer honor.'"

If the distinguished one entertaining his large number of guests, and having a fine specimen of a lackey to wait upon him, is not always Scotch to the core in these little yarns, he is sure to be English, you know, to the backbone; but the part that never varies is where the Irishman from Tipperary crawlsomely addresses the aforesaid as "yer honor," or "yer 'anor." Just fancy a man from gallant Tipperary of all others acting the lickspittle to any person! Is not the thought too absurd to contemplate even for a moment?

We know that the Irishman has always been represented in the low music-halls of England—especially those of London—and by some brainless vulgarians out here, as a hideous being—a cross between a gorilla and a baboon,—wearing a red waist-coast, green coat, and in the band of his hat a pipe; but only ignorant or coarse-minded persons could ever enjoy the caricature. Hence the more modern plan has been devised, and Pat is usually now depicted in Tory newspapers as Sandy's, or more frequently, Mr. J. Bull's tall fine fat lackey. Strange to say there are some individuals of Irish birth or parentage, who still regard the representation as witty. Truly, there is no accounting for shoneen's tastes.—Yours, truly,

P. J. O'DRISCOLL.

August 18, 1900.

The Great National Convention.

Sir,—In the letter of "Thomas Playfair," who is utterly unknown here, there is a very painful reference to all who have the Irish cause at heart in New South Wales. "Playfair" writes: "Few there were who could see anything of good in the leader of the association (Timothy Healy being the leader and his association being that of the People's Rights Association, the latest and the least), but amongst those few I think I may claim the 'Catholic Press.' I was delighted to see that one paper at least had the courage to publish from time to time the Parliamentary achievements of a truly great man, &c.," and finishes by asserting that "those achievements were of more use to the suffering country than a thousand Wild West speeches," or, in other words, those delivered by William O'Brien in forwarding the cause of the United Irish League. Now the chief planks in the platform of the United Irish League have been adopted more than once by the Bishops in council at their conferences in Maynooth, and not only this but by far the largest and most representative convention of the Irish race ever held eagerly adopted every plank in the platform of the United Irish League, which is the result of the "Wild West speeches." Archbishop Croke and Archbishop Walsh have blessed and stimulated the last great convention. A Bishop is one of the treasurers, and distinguished priests proposed and eloquently supported all the principal resolutions. The consequence is that the United Irish League is flourishing throughout the land. Is it going to flourish in New South Wales? The former practical sympathy in an exactly similar occasion of the Irish and Irish sympathisers in this colony goes to prove that they are ready and willing to aid a united Irish party and people.

During the continued incarceration of William O'Brien and John Dillon—but we seem to forget it all now—Timothy Healy had almost attained his object and supremacy through this same Dublin "Freeman." Mr. Grey had then retired, and its control was in Tim's hands. When his object became too apparent he got the sack. Ah, "Mr. Playfair," wasn't it a beautiful paper whilst Timothy was at the helm?

"Mr. Playfair" writes: "Since the commencement of the unfortunate division there was scarcely anything but condemnation in this country for the party known as the People's Rights Association." Oh you sly bouchal! "Commencement of the unfortunate division"; a casual reader might think from this that the Tim Healy's People's Rights Association was contemporaneous with the Parnell split, whilst it is but a feeble, unhealthy anti-national coterie of some months existence. The Irish party split now under the leadership of John Redmond is healed up, and the fracture is the strongest portion of the broken limb. Little thanks, however, to Tim Healy, for he did his poisoned best to alienate Mr. Redmond from William O'Brien previous to the holding of the conference, although he had signed like the other members his name to a pledge of peace and unity. John Redmond knows, William O'Brien knows, that Mr. Parnell in his calm moments could be made reconcilable but for the ever scurrilous language of Mr. Healy.—Yours, &c.,

ROBERT SAMPSON.

The element of difficulty is the very core of all progress. The best path is not the easiest either to find or to tread; but, once found and once trodden, who would retrace his steps?

The Catholic Church is a city to which avenues lead from every side, towards which men may travel from any quarter, by the most diversified roads, by the thorny and rugged ways of strict investigation, by the more flowery paths of sentiment and feeling; but arrived at its precincts, all find that there is but one gate whereby they may enter, but one door to the sheep-fold—narrow and low, perhaps, and causing flesh and blood to stoop in passing in. Men may wander about its outskirts, they may admire the goodliness of its edifices, and of its bulwarks, but they cannot be denizens and children if they enter not by that one gate of absolute, unconditional submission to the teachings of the Church.—Cardinal Wiseman.

There are many joys in life, but few that are so pure, so intense, and so satisfying as the joy of a noble purpose. It is a strange thing that men and women go on year after year fully believing, in spite of experience, that happiness comes only with realisation. They are ever looking forward to the time when something will be finished as the season of enjoyment; the time spent in pursuing, endeavouring, achieving is reckoned as a necessary road to be trodden, and made tolerable only by the thought of what it leads to—a needful toil to be performed, made endurable only by the results that are to follow. No one seems to think that in the march itself there can be any other pleasure than that of having been over so much ground and being so much nearer the desired object. Yet this is certainly an illusion. It is in the purpose itself and in the active exercise of the faculties required to carry it out that the chief happiness of life is found.

SAID THE POET:—

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